

The supreme commander, President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, with the army, navy and air force chiefs and their better halves – Visakhapatnam, February 2006.

'In which manner have we not cooperated?' I queried, composing myself and trying to fathom their response. 'General, we have learnt that the army was strongly opposed to any quota for any religious minority in the army, and is yet to provide the required data to the committee. Whereas in the case of the navy and the air force they have already done so,' asked one of the mediapersons.

Without commenting on what the air force or navy had done, I said, 'the system for entry into the armed forces and for enrolment is based on merit and qualifications; on the ability of an individual to perform the task assigned. We never look at things like where you come from, the language you speak, or the religion you believe in. That has always been our ethos and policy. We are an apolitical, secular and a professional force. Therefore, we consider it important that all Indians get a fair chance of joining the armed forces.' This innocuous statement was aired live by the electronic media as 'breaking news' with the title 'Army Chief rejects the Sachar Committee', or words to that effect, which created quite a stir. It was also carried prominently by most newspapers the next day. As a